

Bubble detachment from circular cavities and flat surfaces

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We determine the maximum stable volume of bubbles attached to flat surfaces as a function of contact radius, contact angle, and capillary length. By solving the Young–Laplace equation using a shooting method, we calculate equilibrium bubble shapes and determine when bubbles detach through three distinct modes: necking at the cavity, sideways instability, and spreading followed by necking on the surrounding surface. Our predicted detachment volumes agree well with experimental measurements of electrolytic, boiling, and carbonated bubbles, as well as pendant drops. These results bring together and extend previous analytical estimates, and by symmetry also apply directly to pendant drops.

1 Introduction

1.1 Motivation

Annually, around 10^{11} kg of hydrogen gas is used in industry, mostly to produce fertilisers via the Haber process and to reduce metal ores in steelmaking and aluminium production¹. Currently, more than 95% of hydrogen is produced from fossil fuels, largely from natural gas via steam methane reforming², which releases significant quantities of CO₂. Diversifying away from fossil fuels is essential to maintain a stable Earth climate system and ensure the long-term survival of human society³. Water electrolysis driven by renewable electricity is a promising alternative¹, splitting water into hydrogen and oxygen without direct CO₂ emissions. However, gas bubbles that form and remain attached to the electrode surface limit the efficiency of water electrolysis. These bubbles block the active area, impede ion transport, and increase ohmic resistance^{4–7}. Electrolysis will also be important for life-support systems on future manned lunar and Martian bases, where water extracted from local ice deposits could provide a source of hydrogen and oxygen⁸. Understanding and controlling bubble detachment is therefore relevant both to improving electrolysis efficiency on Earth and to enabling efficient resource utilisation in low-gravity environments⁹.

Bubble detachment also plays a role in the transport of naturally occurring gases. Methane seepage from the seafloor releases an estimated 6–12 Mt of methane per year from anoxic sediments, geological reservoirs, and degrading methane-hydrate deposits¹⁰. Bubbles with radii below approximately 3 mm can dissolve and biodegrade in the water column before reaching the ocean surface¹¹, whereas larger bubbles can escape into the atmosphere. Since methane is a potent greenhouse gas, understanding the conditions governing bubble detachment and subsequent transport is relevant to quantifying its environmental impact.

1.2 Background

For a bubble attached to a horizontal surface (illustrated in Figure 1) the scale over which surface tension σ balances fluid density contrast $\rho_{\text{out}} - \rho_{\text{in}}$ and gravity g is the capillary length¹²,

$$\lambda \equiv \sqrt{\frac{\sigma}{(\rho_{\text{out}} - \rho_{\text{in}})g}}. \quad (1)$$

The capillary length sets the radius of curvature of the bubble interface due to gravity. Two distinct attachment modes are recognised in the literature¹³. *Pinned* bubbles have a fixed contact radius r_0 , with contact angle ϕ_0 changing as the bubble inflates. *Spreading* bubbles have a fixed contact angle ϕ_0 , with contact radius r_0 changing as the bubble inflates.

For *pinned* bubbles, the classical Tate volume¹⁴ assumes that a bubble detaches when the contact angle reaches $\phi_0 = \pi/2$, balancing buoyancy and surface tension to give $V = 2\pi\lambda^2 r_0$. Chesters¹⁵ refined this in the limit $r_0/\lambda \rightarrow 0$, also assuming detachment at $\phi_0 = \pi/2$. Subsequent experiments, however, show systematic deviations from both models^{16–20}, due to non-spherical interfaces and the onset of asymmetrical instabilities. Stability analyses indicate that the bubble becomes unstable to asymmetrical perturbations for cavity radii $r_0 > 3.219\lambda$ ²¹, and no stable bubble exists at fixed volume for $r_0 > 3.832\lambda$ ²². For such large cavities, lateral detachment from the rim is observed experimentally¹⁹.

The study of *spreading* bubble departure dates back to Fritz²³, who numerically estimated the maximum bubble volume as $V = 0.887\lambda^3 \phi_0^3$ in the limit of small contact angles ϕ_0 . Focusing instead on large contact angles, Phan et al.²⁴ developed an empirical model for bubble departure from nanocoated surfaces. More recent models account for contact-angle hysteresis²⁵, using advancing, receding^{26,27}, or dynamic²⁸ angles as inputs. Experiments, however, reveal systematic deviations from these predictions, particularly for bubbles on superhydrophobic and high-contact-angle surfaces²⁹.

Bubble detachment can also be triggered by coalescence with a neighbouring bubble. Whether neighbouring bubbles coalesce is determined by their width relative to the distance between nucleation sites³⁰. Following coalescence, the merged bubble may either remain attached or detach from the surface, depending on the balance between adhesion and viscous dissipation³¹.

1.3 Aims

Here we treat pinned and spreading bubbles together, rather than as separate problems. We address three fundamental questions:

Q1 What is the volume of the bubble when it detaches?

Q2 How wide does the bubble grow before it detaches?

Q3 How does it detach?

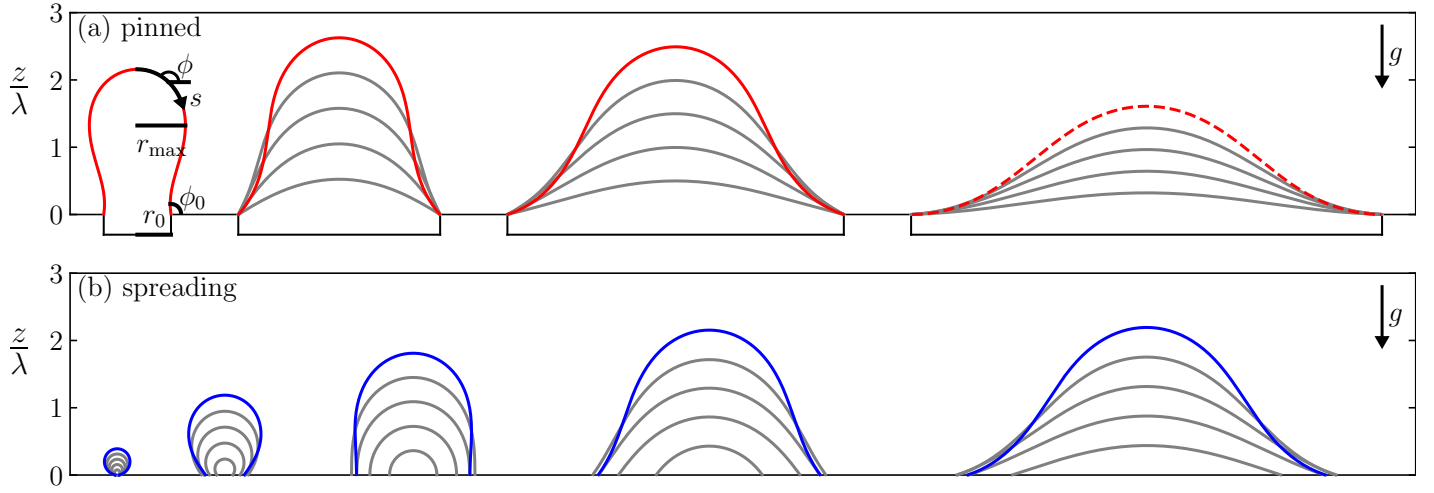


Figure 1 (a) Profiles of pinned bubbles with contact radius $r_0/\lambda \in 0.5, 1.5, 2.5, 3.5$, from left to right. The largest pinned bubble for each contact radius is shown in red. The $r_0 = 3.5\lambda$ profile is dashed to indicate the limiting case $\phi_0 = \pi$, for which the bubble detaches via a non-axisymmetric instability. The coordinate system (ϕ, s) used to solve Equation 9 and the bubble properties ϕ_0 , r_0 , and $r_{\max}$ are shown in black. (b) Profiles of spreading bubbles with contact angle $\phi_0/\pi \in 0.2, 0.4, 0.6, 0.8, 1.0$, from left to right. The largest spreading bubble for each contact angle is shown in blue.

We consider a simplified system consisting of a circular cavity of radius r_0 containing an already-nucleated bubble, surrounded by a smooth horizontal surface with a single-valued, non-hysteretic contact angle ϕ_0 . That is, the contact angle is independent of whether the three-phase contact line advances or recedes. The fluid is quiescent, so forces are purely hydrostatic, and the system is physically equivalent to a pendant drop. Throughout this paper we refer to it as a bubble, but our results apply equally to pendant drops. We determine the detachment size for pinned and spreading bubbles across the full range of cavity sizes, capillary lengths ($0 < r_0/\lambda < \infty$), and contact angles ($0 < \phi_0 < \pi$).

2 Methods

2.1 Governing equation

To calculate the bubble shape, we use and extend the method developed by Fritz²³. Consider a bubble attached to a solid horizontal surface, as depicted in Figure 1. The bubble interface satisfies the Young–Laplace equation³²:

$$\sigma \left(\frac{1}{R_1} + \frac{1}{R_2} \right) = p_{\text{in}} - p_{\text{out}}, \quad (2)$$

where R_1 and R_2 are the principal radii of curvature at a point on the interface, and p_{in} and p_{out} are the pressures inside and outside the bubble, respectively. Assuming both fluid phases are in hydrostatic equilibrium, the pressures at height z are given in terms of the reference pressures $p_{0\text{in}}$ and $p_{0\text{out}}$ at the substrate ($z = 0$):

$$p_{\text{in}}(z) = p_{\text{in}0} - \rho_{\text{in}}gz, \quad (3)$$

$$p_{\text{out}}(z) = p_{\text{out}0} - \rho_{\text{out}}gz. \quad (4)$$

Substituting into Equation 2 and dividing through by the surface tension gives:

$$\frac{1}{R_1} + \frac{1}{R_2} = \frac{p_{\text{in}0} - p_{\text{out}0}}{\sigma} + \frac{z}{\lambda^2}. \quad (5)$$

To eliminate the pressure difference $p_{\text{in}0} - p_{\text{out}0}$, we evaluate Equation 5 at the apex of the bubble, where $z = h$ and the interface is spherical, so we let $R_1 = R_2 = R_h$ the apex radius of curvature:

$$\frac{2}{R_h} = \frac{p_{\text{in}0} - p_{\text{out}0}}{\sigma} + \frac{h}{\lambda^2}. \quad (6)$$

Subtracting this from Equation 5 gives:

$$\frac{1}{R_1} + \frac{1}{R_2} = \frac{2}{R_h} + \frac{z - h}{\lambda^2}. \quad (7)$$

Assuming the bubble is axisymmetric about the vertical axis, we describe the interface shape in terms of arc length s from the apex, distance from the axis r , and the angle ϕ between the interface tangent and the horizontal. The two principal curvatures can be found through trigonometry³³:

$$R_1 = \frac{ds}{d\phi}, \quad R_2 = \frac{r}{\sin \phi}. \quad (8)$$

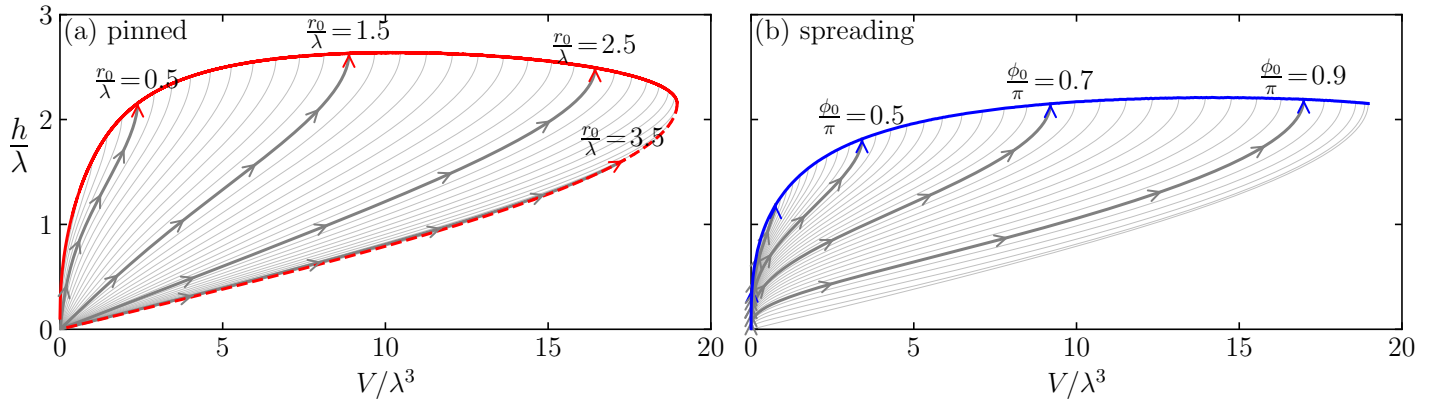


Figure 2 Bubble height h and volume V during evolution. (a) Grey lines: pinned bubbles with constant contact radius r_0 . Solid red line: locus where $\partial V/\partial h = 0$, and the bubbles detach axisymmetrically. Dashed red line: locus where $\phi_0 = \pi$ and the bubbles detach from the side of the cavity. (b) Grey lines: spreading bubbles with constant contact angle ϕ_0 . Solid blue line: locus where $\partial V/\partial h = 0$, and the bubbles detach axisymmetrically. In (a) and (b), thick grey lines and arrows correspond to the bubbles shown in Figure 1.

Substituting into Equation 7 and multiplying by the capillary length yields the governing equation for the bubble shape:

$$\lambda \frac{d\phi}{ds} + \frac{\lambda \sin \phi}{r} = \frac{2\lambda}{R_h} + \frac{z-h}{\lambda}. \quad (9)$$

This equation describes the curvature of an axisymmetric interface under gravity. Here, all lengths are scaled by the capillary length λ , so that Equation 9 is dimensionless, implying self-similar bubble shapes and a universal scaling with λ .

2.2 Numerical solution

We solve Equation 9 using a shooting method, initiating the integration at the apex ($r=0, z=h, \phi=\pi$) and sampling 10^4 logarithmically spaced initial guesses for R_h over $10^{-3}\lambda < R_h < 10^3\lambda$. The equations are integrated along the arc length s with a step size of $10^{-5}\lambda$ using the Adams–Bashforth method³³. The complete set of calculations requires approximately 250 s on a single core of an M4 MacBook Pro. The C code and accompanying data are freely available³⁴.

For pinned bubbles, the boundary condition $r=r_0$ is imposed at the substrate ($z=0$). For a given cavity radius r_0 , this yields a family of equilibrium profiles with different apex radii R_h , shown in Figure 1a. For spreading bubbles, the boundary condition $\phi=\phi_0$ is imposed at the substrate ($z=0$). The resulting profiles are shown in Figure 1b for a sequence of contact angles and apex radii R_h .

3 Results and Discussion

3.1 Bubble detachment criteria

To characterize the evolution of a growing pinned bubble, we plot the bubble height h as a function of volume V in Figure 2a, where the bubble volume

$$V = \int_0^h \pi r^2 dz, \quad (10)$$

is integrated using the midpoint rule. Each family of solutions in Figure 1a gives rise to a curve $h(V)$ in Figure 2a. Upon nucleation inside the cavity, the bubble has zero volume and zero height, corresponding to the bottom-left point in Figure 2a. As the bubble grows, its volume V and height h increase, and it remains attached to the substrate until one of two conditions is met:

1. The bubble volume reaches a point where the $h(V)$ curve becomes vertical, i.e., $\partial V/\partial h = 0$, so that the height can increase without a further increase in volume. The solution is no longer unique, and the interface becomes unstable, leading to axisymmetric detachment.
2. The contact angle ϕ_0 reaches π , at which point the interface is horizontal at the contact line and becomes unstable to non-axisymmetric perturbations²¹. The bubble shifts to one side of the cavity and detaches laterally. This occurs for all $h(V)$ curves with $r_0 > 3.219\lambda$, at the lower right of Figure 2a.

We truncate each of the $h(V)$ curves in Figure 2a when either of these conditions is met. We note that the tallest possible bubble occurs in a cavity of radius $r_0 = 1.720\lambda$ and has height $h = 2.642\lambda$, which is considerably less than the analytical limit of $h = 3.42\lambda$ established for two-dimensional columnar pendant drops³⁵.

In Figure 2b, we perform the same $h(V)$ analysis for spreading bubbles. The figure shows the possible volumes and heights for contact angles spanning the full range $0 < \phi_0 < \pi$. As for pinned bubbles, each curve reaches a point where $h(V)$ becomes vertical ($\partial V/\partial h = 0$). This point defines the detachment volume, and the curve is truncated there. In the spreading bubble case, detachment is always axisymmetric, and the tallest spreading bubble is shorter, with $h = 2.213\lambda$ and contact angle $\phi_0 = 0.8330\pi$.

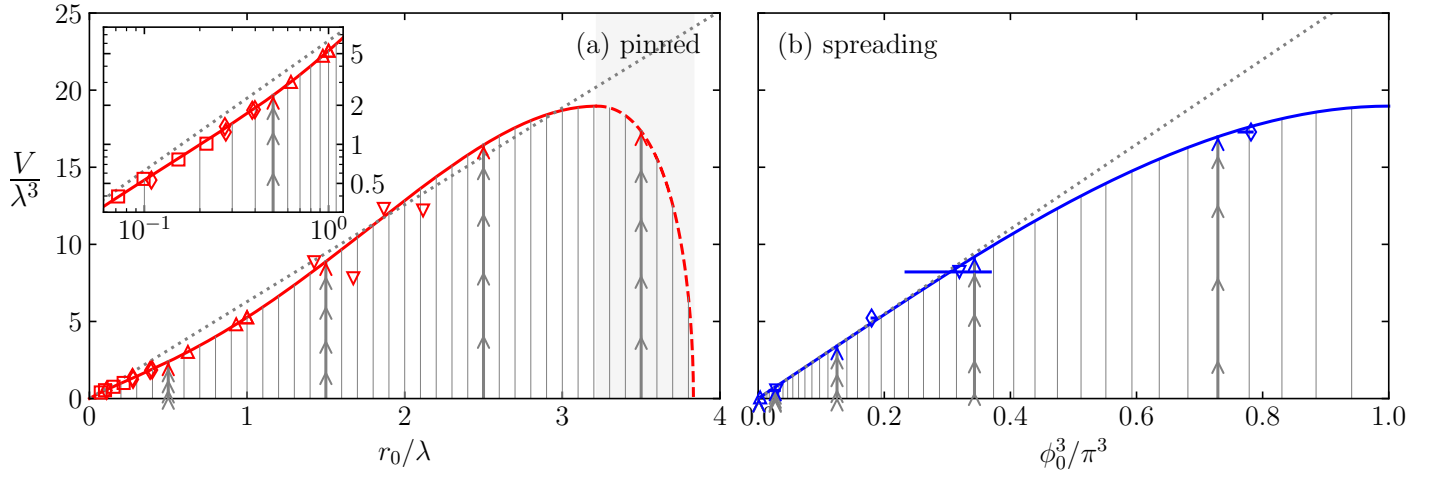


Figure 3 (a) Volume V of pinned bubbles. The red line shows the detachment volume as a function of contact radius r_0 , while the dotted grey line, $V = 2\pi\lambda^2 r_0$, shows the Tate prediction¹⁴. The shaded region $3.219\lambda < r_0 < 3.832\lambda$ and dashed red line indicate where ϕ_0 reaches π and the bubble becomes unstable to asymmetric perturbations. Empty symbols denote detachment volumes measured in experiments: squares¹⁷, diamonds¹⁸, down-triangles¹⁹, and up-triangles²⁰. Inset: same data on a logarithmic scale, showing the small-radius range in greater detail. (b) Volume V of spreading bubbles. The solid blue line shows the detachment volume as a function of contact angle ϕ_0 , which is cubed to allow comparison with the Fritz²³ prediction $V = 0.887\lambda^3 \phi_0^3$ (dotted grey line). Empty symbols denote detachment volumes measured in experiments: up-triangles²⁷, down-triangles²⁶, and diamonds²⁹; error bars indicate advancing and receding contact angles. In (a) and (b), thick grey lines and arrows correspond to the bubbles shown in Figure 1.

3.2 Bubble volume

Figure 3(a) shows the possible volumes $V(r_0)$ of pinned bubbles. The detachment volume initially increases with contact radius, following a trend close to the Tate prediction¹⁴; however, deviations arise due to the non-spherical interface shape induced by buoyancy. These deviations are consistent with experimental measurements of bubbles emitted from tubes in water¹⁷, bubbles in carbonated water from millimetric cavities¹⁸, and pendant drops²⁰. At $r_0 = 3.219\lambda$, we obtain the largest pinned bubble relative to the capillary length λ , with a volume of $V = 18.96\lambda^3$. For larger contact radii, detachment occurs via a non-axisymmetric instability, and the detachment volume decreases. For $r_0 > 3.832\lambda$, no stable bubble exists.

Figure 3(b) shows the possible volumes $V(\phi_0)$ of spreading bubbles. For small contact angles, the Fritz prediction is accurate. As $\phi_0 \rightarrow \pi$, however, the detachment volume saturates below Fritz's prediction. Our results are confirmed by measurements of water electrolysis²⁷, boiling²⁶, and air bubbles over superhydrophobic surfaces²⁹. The largest spreading bubble has $V = 18.96\lambda^3$, and is identical in shape to the largest pinned bubble.

3.3 Bubble coalescence

When two bubbles nucleate near each other on a surface, they may coalesce, and the energy released during coalescence can lead to detachment³¹. Assuming that coalescence occurs when neighbouring bubbles touch, and that the bubbles have the same shape, coalescence occurs when their separation is less than or equal to $2r_{\max}$, where $r_{\max}$ is the maximum horizontal radius of the bubble, as labelled in Figure 1. Figure 4a shows the maximum value of $r_{\max}$ reached by pinned bubbles during their evolution up to detachment. For small contact radii, $r_{\max}/\lambda \approx (r_0/\lambda)^{1/3}$, so we expect bubbles to coalesce when the distance between their nucleation centres is less than $2r_0^{1/3}$. For large contact radii, ($r_0 > \lambda$), we find $r_{\max} = r_0$, indicating that the bubble does not protrude beyond the cavity; hence, coalescence cannot occur between bubbles nucleated on neighbouring cavities.

3.4 Pinning and unpinning of the contact line

Figure 5a shows the contact angle ϕ_0 at detachment. For small contact radii ($r_0 < 0.1\lambda$), the assumption of Tate and Chesters^{14,15} that the contact angle at detachment is $\pi/2$ holds. However, ϕ_0 at detachment is larger than $\pi/2$ for all other contact radii. This explains why the predictions of Tate and Chesters agree well with our results for small contact radii, but deviate as buoyancy effects become stronger. Figure 3d shows the radius of the bubble contact area at departure, which closely follows the fit $r_0 = 3.219\lambda(\phi_0/\pi)^2$. Figure 3d also shows the maximum radius of the contact area during bubble evolution. In all cases, the maximum contact radius exceeds the departure radius, indicating that the contact line initially spreads and then partially recedes prior to detachment. In some instances¹⁶, the contact radius may again equal the cavity radius r_0 , re-pinning the bubble at the cavity, in which case the departure volume corresponds to V .

Indeed, for cavities with $r_0 > 3.219\lambda$, ϕ_0 reaches π and the interface becomes unstable to non-axisymmetric perturbations²¹, causing the bubble to slide to one side and detach laterally. No stable solution exists for $r_0 > 3.832\lambda$ ²²; above this radius, Equation 9 has no solution with $\phi_0 < \pi$, and lateral detachment is immediate, consistent with the dripping behaviour reported in sessile drop experiments¹⁹.

Figure 5c also shows the minimum contact angle reached during bubble evolution. If the surface contact angle exceeds this minimum, the bubble becomes unpinned and spreads across the surface. The minimum angle closely follows the fit $\phi_0/\pi = \sqrt{r_0/(3.5\lambda)}$.

Figure 6 gives the decision tree for bubble evolution up to detachment. Given ϕ_0 , r_0 , and the capillary length λ of a specific system, the detachment size is determined by following this tree, using the functions plotted in Figure 3. Table 1 gives the properties of the limiting

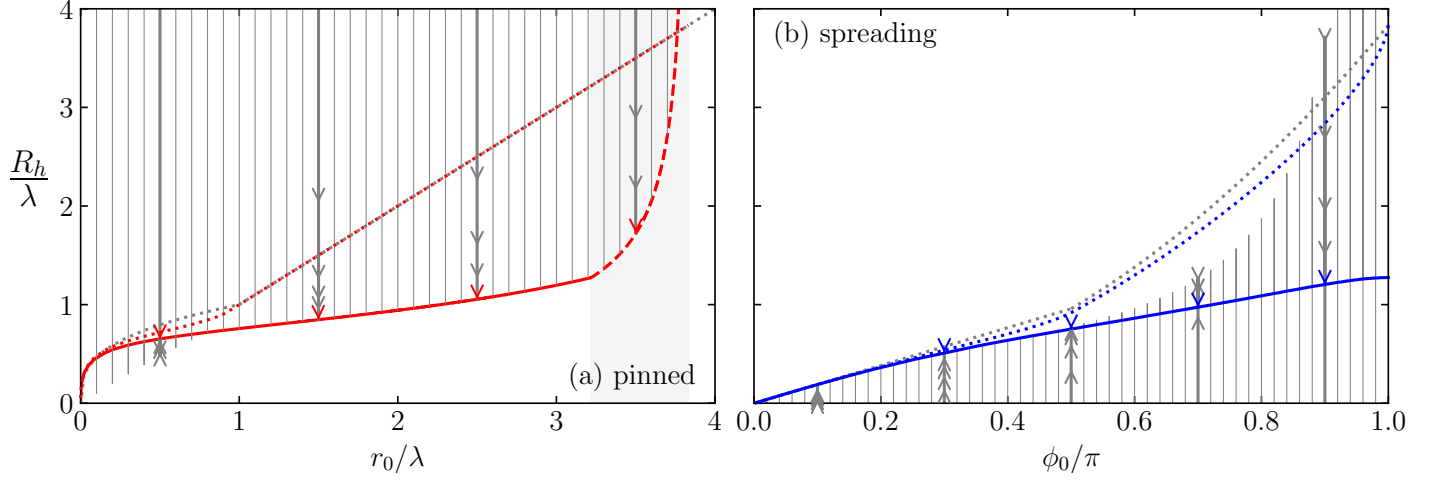


Figure 4 (a) Apex radius of curvature R_h of pinned bubbles as a function of contact radius r_0 . The red line shows R_h at detachment. The shaded region $3.219\lambda < r_0 < 3.832\lambda$ and dashed red line indicate where ϕ_0 reaches π and the bubble becomes unstable to asymmetric perturbations. The dotted red line shows the maximum horizontal radius $r_{\max}$ reached during evolution, and the dotted grey line shows the piecewise fit $r_{\max}/\lambda = (r_0/\lambda)^{1/3}$ for $r_0 < \lambda$ and $r_{\max} = r_0$ for $r_0 > \lambda$. (b) Apex radius of curvature R_h of spreading bubbles as a function of contact angle ϕ_0 . The solid blue line shows R_h at detachment; the dotted blue line shows the maximum horizontal radius $r_{\max}$ reached during evolution; and the dotted grey line shows the piecewise fit $r_{\max}/\lambda = 3.832\phi_0/(2\pi)$ for $\phi_0 < \pi/2$ and $r_{\max} = 3.832(\phi_0/\pi)^2$ for $\phi_0 > \pi/2$. In (a) and (b), vertical grey solid lines show the evolution of R_h up to detachment, with arrowheads corresponding to the bubbles shown in Figure 1.

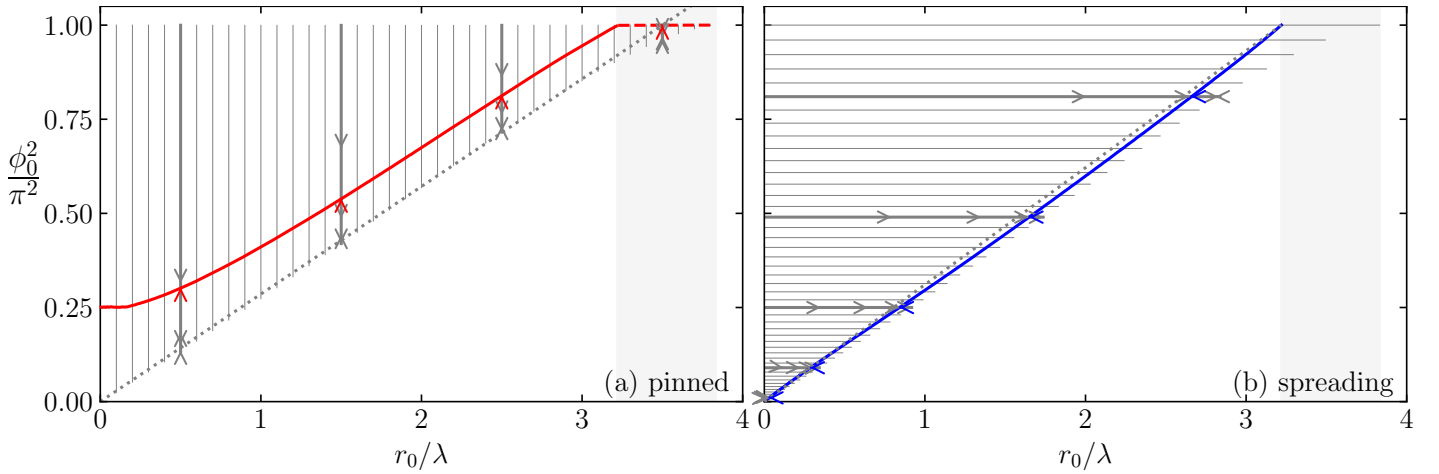


Figure 5 (a) Contact angle ϕ_0 of pinned bubbles with fixed contact radius r_0 . The red line shows ϕ_0 at detachment and is dashed where $\phi_0 = \pi$ and detachment occurs non-axisymmetrically. Vertical grey lines and arrows show the evolution of ϕ_0 up to detachment. The dotted grey line shows the fit $r_0 = 3.5\lambda(\phi_0/\pi)^2$. (b) Contact radius r_0 of spreading bubbles with fixed contact angle ϕ_0 . The solid blue line shows r_0 at detachment, and the dotted grey line shows the fit $r_0 = 3.219\lambda(\phi_0/\pi)^2$. In (a) and (b), grey lines and arrows show the evolution up to detachment, and the shaded region indicates $3.219\lambda < r_0 < 3.832\lambda$.

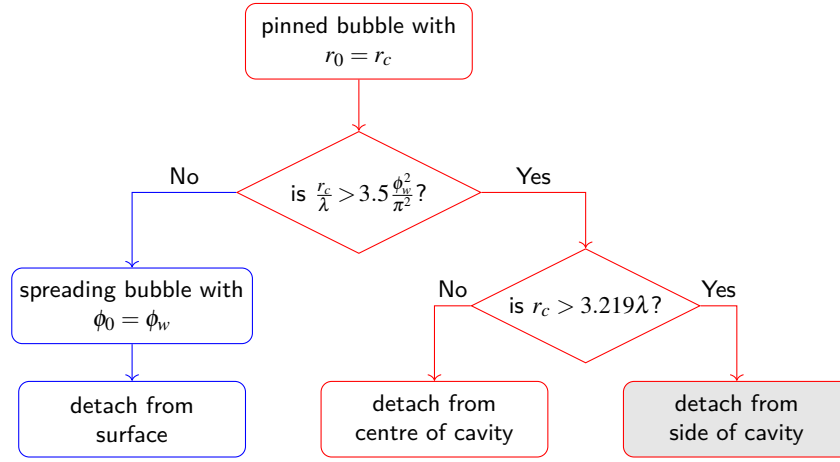


Figure 6 Decision tree for bubble detachment. Red branches correspond to pinned bubbles and blue branches to spreading bubbles. The cavity radius is r_c and the wetting angle on the surrounding substrate is ϕ_w .

Table 1 Key properties of significant bubbles, expressed in units of the capillary length λ . Shown are the contact angle ϕ_0 , contact radius r_0 , apex height h , apex radius of curvature R_h , volume V . Extremal quantities are highlighted in bold

Significance	ϕ_0/π	r_0/λ	h/λ	R_h/λ	V/λ^3
Largest pinned bubble	1.000	3.219	2.152	1.274	18.96
Largest spreading bubble	1.000	3.219	2.152	1.274	18.96
Tallest pinned bubble	0.7750	1.720	2.642	0.8867	10.62
Tallest spreading bubble	0.8330	2.297	2.213	1.126	14.48
Largest stable contact radius	1.000	3.832	0.000	∞	0.000

bubble configurations, where we see that the largest pinned and spreading bubbles in fact correspond to the same solution of Equation 9. Note that we measure the bubble volume above the contact line; some gas may remain attached to the surface after detachment, so the true released volume may be slightly less.

4 Conclusions

4.1 Answers to the two key questions

We now return to the two questions posed at the outset.

Answer to Q1. The detachment volume depends on whether the bubble is pinned or spreading. For pinned bubbles, the detachment volume rises nearly linearly with cavity radius, closely following the Tate prediction $V = 2\pi\lambda^2 r_0$, with quantitative corrections arising from the non-spherical interface shape under buoyancy (Figure 3). For spreading bubbles, the detachment volume increases monotonically with contact angle and saturates at $V_s = 18.96\lambda^3$ as $\phi_0 \rightarrow \pi$, below the Fritz extrapolation (Figure 3b). Both results are confirmed by independent experimental datasets spanning electrolytic, boiling, and carbonated bubbles, as well as pendant drops.

Answer to Q2. The detachment mode is determined by which threshold is reached first during bubble growth (Figure 6). A pinned bubble detaches axisymmetrically from the cavity centre when its volume reaches the maximum of the r_0 curve; it detaches laterally when the contact angle reaches $\phi_0 = \pi$, which occurs only for $r_0 > 3.219\lambda$; and it transitions to spreading mode when the contact angle ϕ_0 falls below the contact angle ϕ_0 on the surrounding substrate. A spreading bubble then detaches from the surface when its volume reaches V_s . No stable bubble exists for $r_0 > 3.832\lambda$, above which lateral detachment is immediate.

4.2 Outlook

In summary, we have computed the maximum stable volume of axisymmetric bubbles on flat surfaces as a function of contact radius and contact angle, using a numerical solution of the Young–Laplace equation. The results unify the pinned and spreading detachment modes within a single framework, recover the classical Tate and Fritz limits, and identify the thresholds at which non-axisymmetric instabilities govern departure. All results scale universally with the capillary length λ and apply equally to pendant drops. The numerical code used in this study is freely available³⁴, and can provide an exact detachment criterion for full electrolyser simulations such as that of Ross *et al.*⁷, as well as quantitative guidance for designing electrodes with optimised wettability and cavity geometry to promote early bubble detachment and improve electrolysis efficiency. In future work, the model can be extended to account for heterogeneous surfaces, which give rise to contact angle hysteresis.

5 Data availability

The data and code that support the findings of this article are openly available on Zenodo at <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20720640> (ref. 34).

6 Author Contributions

I. Cannon: conceptualisation, software, formal analysis, visualisation, writing – original draft. S. Endres: software, writing – review & editing. M. Avila: conceptualisation, methodology, writing – review & editing. L. Mädler: conceptualisation, methodology, writing – review & editing.

7 Conflicts of interest

There are no conflicts to declare.

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